

LIN7209 – Syntax

Reconstruction

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Plan for today

- Review Principle A and see cases in which it does not seem to work as expected; propose reconstruction as a fix.
- Review other cases in which reconstruction appears to be needed.

A closer look at Principle A

Principle A

- Anaphors must be **locally bound**.
- Binding is C-Command and coreference.
- A node C-Commands exactly everything its sister (strictly) dominates.
- Coreference is established by a successful coindexation (respecting Φ -features etc.).

Successes of Principle A

- (1) a. Alice₁ drew a picture of herself₁.
b. * Herself₁ drew a picture of Alice₁.
- (2) a. A picture of herself₁ fell on Alice₁.
b. * A picture of Alice₁ fell on herself₁.

Initial issues with Principle A

- The following sentences are expected to check Principle A (why?)

(3) * That girl₁, herself₁ likes. Topicalization

(4) * Herself₁ likes every girl₁. (Quantifier raising)

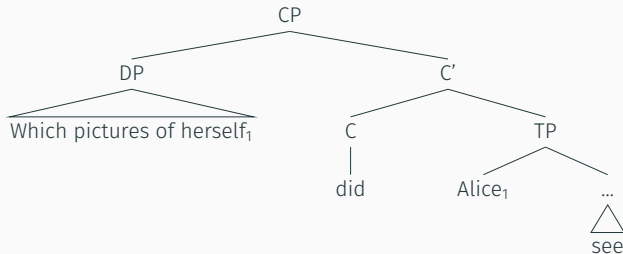
(5) * Which girl₁ did Anson persuade herself₁ that David met?
wh-movement

- Solution: **restrict binding to certain positions** for the binder: A (“argument”) positions (e.g. subject, object, indirect object etc.). Includes Spec-TP, **excludes Spec-CP**.
- A-Binding is binding from an A-position.
- Principle A then states that **anaphors must be locally A-bound**.
- The sentences above then violate Principle A because their binders are in Spec-CP so cannot A-bind!

More problems

- The sentence below is expected to be * (why?)

(6) Which pictures of herself₁ did Alice₁ see?



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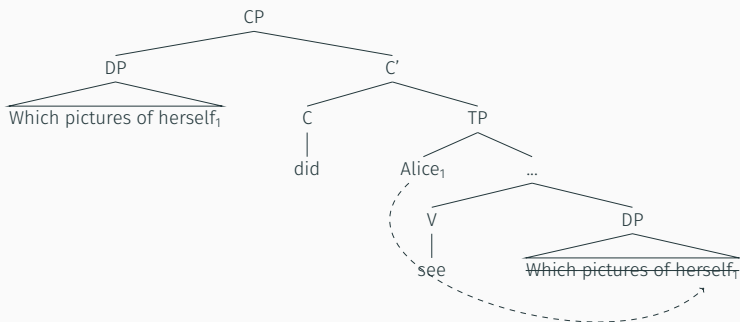
- Maybe the data is incorrectly interpreted (e.g. *herself* is **not an anaphor**, Pollard and Sag 1992).
- Maybe Principle A could be restated so it captures the example (David and I don't know of anyone that has said this).
- Maybe **the structure is not what it appears to be, so that Principle A is met** (this is the standard solution).

Rephrasing Binding

- We slightly update what it means for a DP to bind another DP.
- A DP α binds a DP β iff α and β are coindexed and α C-Commands β **or a trace of a phrase containing** β .
- Interpreting a moved DP in its original position for the purposes of binding is called **reconstruction**.

Back to the *wh*-anaphor case

(6) Which pictures of herself₁ did Alice₁ see?



- Essentially, (6) is good, because (7) is.

(7) Alice₁ saw some picture of herself₁.

Is reconstruction mandatory or optional?

(8) * Alice₁ said the boy had sold some pictures of herself₁.

- Why is (8) correctly predicted to be bad? Herself is not *locally* bound!
- Then why is (9) fine?

(9) Alice₁ asked which pictures of herself₁ the boy had sold.

- For (9) to make sense, one must consider the binding configuration obtained **after *wh*-movement takes place**.
- But in (6), we had to consider the binding configuration ***prior to wh*-movement...**

(6) Which pictures of herself₁ did Alice₁ see?

When to bind, when to reconstruct?

(6) Which pictures of herself₁ did Alice₁ see?

(9) Alice₁ asked which pictures of herself₁ the boy had sold.

- Maybe in (6), Alice move covertly to a higher position, and this way we can always have binding *after* *wh*-movement? This may have bad consequences very quickly.
- Or, **we allow binding to apply prior to movement, optionally**, to “rescue” the sentence. This is called reconstruction, because it can be understood as the bindee being interpreted back where it was before movement.

A more elaborate argument for reconstruction

- I adapted these sentences from David who adapted them from Fox (1999). I hope I did not lose the point!
- (10) One student is expected (by the convenor) [t_1 to pass every module with honors].
- (10) has **two readings**:
 1. The convenor expects one fixed student (say, Jo) to pass every module.
 2. The convenor expects one student to pass Syntax (say, Jo), one to pass CompLing (say, Al), one to pass morphology etc.
- **Reading 1 comes for free** from the surface scope/C-Command relations: *one student* > *every module*.
- To get reading 2 we can:
 - Quantifier-raise (QR) *every module* to the matrix to outscope *one student*.
 - Interpret *one student* lower than its surface position (**reconstruction**), and keep QR local (within the embedded clause).

An more elaborate argument for reconstruction cont'd

- Let's replace *convenor* by *his own mother*...
- (11) One student₁ is expected by his₁ own mother [_{t₁} to pass every module with honors].
- Which reading(s) do we get now?
 1. One fixed student (say, Jo) is expected by Jo's mother to pass every module.
 2. ~~One student (say Jo) is expected by Jo's mother to pass Syntax, one (say Al) is expected by Al's mother to pass CompLing (say, Al) etc.~~
 - If the QR analysis were correct, we'd expect Reading 2 to be available here, because nothing would block *every module* from moving up.
 - If the reconstruction analysis is correct, Reading 2 is out in (11)! This is because, if reconstruction happens, then *student* can no longer bind *his own*, leading to a Principle A violation. So **reconstruction is superior**.

Reconstruction for other cases

Movement as copy deletion: the Copy Theory

- Recall MOVE is RE-MERGE... so we expect **moved elements to be copied in the narrow syntax!**
- Phonological Forms normally **realize only one copy fully** (though remember the multiple/partial copy examples from last week!)
- Logical Forms (for semantics) are also subject to economy principles that regulate the deletion of superfluous copies, and may result in **stripped-down structures** like the following:

(6') [~~Which pictures of herself_T~~] did Alice₁ see [~~Which pictures of herself₁~~]?
(Note: In the original image, the first bracketed phrase is crossed out with a red line.)

- Such structures undergo Determiner Replacement: the determiner in the lower copy gets replaced with *the*.¹

(12) [which x] Alice₁ see [**the** x: x is pictures of herself₁]

¹They also undergo Variable Insertion, which inserts an NP predicate $\lambda y. y = x$, s.t. x can be bound by Predicate Abstraction.

Principle B

- (13)
- a. Alice asked Mark to comb himself/*him.
 - b. Alice asked Mark to comb *herself/her.
 - c. Alice asked Sue to comb *himself/him.
- Pronouns and anaphors appear in **complementary distributions**.
 - Principle B: a pronoun must be **A-free (not A-bound)** in its local **domain**.
 - If a sentence contains a pronoun that is locally A-bound, then the sentence is ungrammatical.

- (14) a. * Alice asked Mark to comb Mark.
b. * Alice asked Mark to comb Alice.

- Principle C: a referring expression (R-expression) **must be A-free (not A-bound) simpliciter** (no locality!).
- If a sentence contains a R-expression that is A-bound, then the sentence is ungrammatical.

Reconstruction and Binding Principles B and C

(15) * Sarah asked how proud of herself the boy was.

- If reconstruction happens:

(16) * Sarah₁ asked [how proud of herself] the boy was [how proud of herself₁].

‘Sarah asked what is the degree d s.t. the boy was proud to that degree d ?’

- After reconstruction, the **anaphor is no longer locally bound!**
Explaining *.
- For this to work one must however assume that **reconstruction of the restrictor of APs is obligatory**—converging evidence that it’s the case.

More cases of faulty reconstruction with Binding

- Again using APs forcing reconstruction...

(17) Principle B

- a. * How proud of him is Anson?
- b. * How proud of him did Karen say Anson was?
- c. How proud of him did Anson say Karen was?

(18) Principle C

- a. * How proud of Anson is he?
- b. * How proud of Anson did Karen say he was?
- c. * How proud of Anson did he say Karen was?

Bound variable Anaphora

- (19) **No** woman denies that **she** has written a best selling novel.
Available: No woman x is s.t. x denies to have written a best selling novel.
- (20) **Every** woman said **she** had met the Shah.
Available: Every woman x is s.t. x said x met the Shah.
- (21) Did **any** woman say that **she** had met the Shah?
Available: is it the case that some woman x is s.t. x said that x had met the Shah?
- (22) **Every** woman persuaded **her** son to organize **her** birthday party.
Available: Every woman x is s.t. x persuaded x 's (unique/salient) son to organize x 's birthday party.
- (23) **Each** author decided that **she** should be at the signing.
Available: Each author x is s.t. x decided that x should be at the signing.
- Bound variable anaphora available for all quantifiers (even negative existentials!), under C-Command. No locality condition.

Bound Variable Anaphora cont'd

- Is C-Command necessary?

(24) **She** persuaded the Shah that **every** woman should be imprisoned.

~~Every woman x is s.t. x persuaded the Shah that x /every woman should be imprisoned.~~

(25) **She** didn't believe that I had been introduced to **any** woman.

~~Some woman x is s.t. x does not believe that I had been introduced to x .~~

(26) **She** expected that **each** author's book signing would be private.

~~Each author x is s.t. x expected that x 's book signing would be private.~~

- Bound readings require C-Command!

Reconstruction for semantic binding

- (27) The sybils decree that **no** man may love **his** closest relative.
Available: The sybils decree that no man x is s.t. x may love x 's closets relative.
- (28) Which of **his** relatives did the sybils decree that **no** man may love?
Available: Which is the y s.t. did the sybils decree that **no** man x may love y , with y the relative of x ?
- Bound reading only possible if *his relatives* reconstructs below *no man*!
- (29) Which of his relatives forced the sybils to decree that no man was innocent?
~~Which is the y s.t. y forced the sybils decree that **no** man x is innocent, with y the relative of x ?~~
- No bound reading if there's no reconstruction site below *no man*.

Reconstruction for semantic binding (other examples)

- (30) You persuaded the gallery that **every** artist liked **his** landscape pictures best.
Bound reading available.
- (31) Which of **his** pictures did you persuade the gallery that **every** artist liked best?
Bound reading available.
- (32) **His** landscape pictures persuaded the gallery that **every** artist likes flowers best.
No bound reading.
- (33) Which of **his** pictures persuaded the gallery that **every** artist likes flowers best?
No bound reading.

Reconstruction for scope

(34) [Someone from New York]₁ is expected [t₁ to win the lottery].

- Two readings:
 - “High” reading of the existential: somebody from NY (say Jo) is s.t. Jo is expected to win the lottery. Scenario: we know for a fact that Jo bought 90% of all tickets.
 - “Low” reading of the existential: it is expected that someone from NY (could be Jo, could be Al...) will win the lottery. Scenario: we know for a fact that all NYers together bought 90% of the tickets: Jo bought 1%, Al 1% etc.
- We get the **high reading for free** from the surface scope.
- To get the low reading, reconstruction is the most plausible solution!²

²Alternative: raise *expected* but it's not a quantifier over individuals...

Reconstruction for idiom interpretation

- Idioms are chunks that have a meaning vastly independent from the individual meanings of their parts.
- For that reason, idioms need to be interpreted as a chunk by the semantic module...

(35) “Take care”

- a. Bill needs a lot of care. *But I’m sure Fred will take it of him.
 - b. How much care do you think Fred took of Bill?
- The idiom can be interpreted as such only if *care* is reconstructed near *took*!

Summary

- Mostly reconstruction involves a cases where:
 - usually a certain **syntactic configuration** (e.g. C-Command, selectional locality) is needed to give a certain **semantic effect** (e.g. bound variable readings, scope, idiom interpretation);
 - but **that configuration is not available in the surface syntax**: so there's a syntax-semantics mismatch.
- We also get “reconstruction” for grammatical phenomena like case, though this is usually called **case connectivity**:

(36) HIM/*HE, I want to fire.